For a lot of major writers like Don DeLillo or Philip Roth, their novels become shorter and more impressionistic towards the latter stages of their careers—as style crystallises with age, brevity becomes an embedded virtue of sorts. Amit Chaudhuri, however, has been writing these short, observational, impeccably crafted short novels since the beginning of his career; his first, *A Strange and Sublime Address*, was published in 1991. Three decades later, the observations remain razor-sharp and the sentences as languorously beautiful as ever.

Chaudhuri's latest book, a short novel called *Sojourn*, follows the unnamed protagonist through a six-month residency in Berlin circa 2005, a guest professorship. He isn't sure whether he has been to this city before—and of course, less than two decades ago, this was actually two cities, before the Cold War ended and the Berlin Wall fell. Almost every encounter he has—whether it's with Faqrul, the Bangladeshi writer, or Geeta, the Bengali German postcolonial scholar, or Birgit, a woman he's kind-of sort-of involved with—leaves him disoriented and second-guessing himself in one way or another. Identity, history and the porosity of memory are all major themes in this allusive novel.

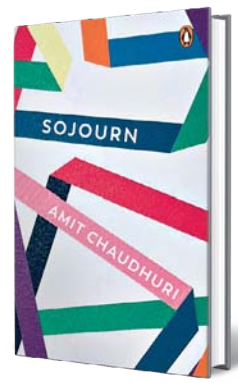
During a video interview, Chaudhuri tells INDIA TODAY, "It's an attempt to make sense out of my response not only to Berlin, but also to a foreign city that feels curiously intimate to the person who arrives there. To make sense of an odd intimation of having arrived at home, to recognise that this history before me is somehow also my history."

In the Fall Semester of 2005/ 2006, Chaudhuri was the Samuel Fischer guest professor at FU (Freie Universität) Berlin, living in the city for six months and engaging with students and faculty. This experience formed the outlines of the novelist's latest work. Describing his own real-life stint in Berlin, Chaudhuri says: "I was struck gradually by this sense of being very much at home in Berlin in a way that I don't necessarily feel in London or even in Indian cities. So, I was trying to think of where this sense of arrival comes from. And possibly, also the idea of having been there before and forgotten... the idea of memory being contingent and subject to erasures and resurfacing began to come to me."

As always with Chaudhuri's work, the mundane is centred both narratively and at the symbolic level. When the narrator shifts from a smaller apartment to a significantly larger one at the beginning of the book, the first thing he notes is the new place's lavish bathroom and toilet. "What other room do you own so completely?" notes the narrator, as though reaffirming his preoccupation with the toilet's size.

"Scatology, the whole ethos of the toilet, I've always been interested in that," Chaudhuri says. "It's part of my terrain, part of where my imagination goes towards. In *A Strange and Sublime Address*, there's a lot of stuff going on about bathrooms and toilets. It's in *Afternoon Raag* as well, the sound of flushing has been described as 'candid gurgling'. These are places of importance to me, places of secrecy and the imagination for both the observer and the occupant."

At several points in the novel, the idea of socialism's 'defeat' (and what now seems to be its global extinction) affecting the narrator and how he engages with others is subtly hinted at. As Chaudhuri explains, this had very little to do with one's personal political beliefs. It was an abstract kind of loss, but one that felt real at the experiential level. "When I was growing up, the world was divided into socialism and the free market, and the places that fell in between these two poles," Chaudhuri says. "The knowledge that socialism exists in the world made you a particular kind of human being, regardless of which pole you believed in. A world where socialism did not exist as an option felt unthinkable."



SOJOURN
by Amit Chaudhuri
PENGUIN HAMISH HAMILTON
₹499; 176 pages

Like Amit Chaudhuri's previous novels, **SOJOURN**, too, is marked by razor-sharp observations and languorously beautiful sentences

India in the 1970s (when Chaudhuri was growing up) was one of the aforementioned places that "fell in between these two poles". According to the author, people living in these parts of the world felt "unmoored" when the Cold War ended and the socialist state of East Germany ceased to be. Indeed, at one point, *Sojourn*'s narrator thinks, "I've lost my bearings—not in the city; in its history."

Enzo Traverso, historian and professor at Cornell, published a book called *Left-Wing Melancholia: Marxism, History and Memory* (2016, Columbia University Press). It describes the "melancholic vision of history as a series of losses" that was triggered when the Berlin Wall fell. Though Chaudhuri only read the book after he had finished writing *Sojourn*, he felt that this phrase and the book's thesis resonated with what *Sojourn*'s unnamed narrator experiences. "I wrote to the author afterwards, telling him that the melancholia was not limited to the left-wing," Chaudhuri says. "This wasn't about political beliefs, not really. Even if you identified as 'apolitical', you still felt a sense of loss."

Sojourn is a novel that both demands and rewards close reading. Its slow-burning melancholia and historical resonances will stay with you long after the last sentence has gracefully uncoiled itself. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha